thiscode — Easiest Setup Guide

Even first-time users finish in 5 steps

Who this guide is for

OK even if you've barely used a terminal. Copy + paste + Enter, one line at a time.

What you need

- An internet-connected computer (Mac / Linux / WSL — Windows native to come later)
- Claude Code (install from https://claude.com/code)
- 5~30 minutes (depending on the Tier you pick)

Written 2026-05-13 | v1.0

1. Before You Begin — The Whole Flow at a Glance

In one line, the flow looks like this:

0. **Environment check**

→

1. **Plugin install**

→

2. **Search MCP**

→

3. **Obsidian branch**

→

4. **GraphRAG (optional)**

→

5. **Healthcheck**

Each step ends with a ✓ **This is what success looks like** checkpoint. If it fails, stop at that step — don't move on.

1.1. What is the km plugin's 4-Tier search?

The km plugin's 4-Tier search tries GraphRAG → Obsidian CLI → Obsidian MCP → text search. It moves on when an earlier stage is unavailable or fails. ThisCode scripts install local tools; `/km:search` runs search; `/km:setup` configures storage, Obsidian MCP, and settings.

- **Tier 1 — GraphRAG** — graph and semantic search through a configured server
- **Tier 2 — Obsidian CLI** — search Obsidian documents
- **Tier 3 — Obsidian MCP** — the Obsidian integration configured in km
- **Tier 4 — text search** — use an available text-search tool

The vault-search MCP in Step 2 is a separate local embedding tool. It substitutes for no km tier and is not required to use `/km:search`.

Tip — Configure km first and start with available text search or the CLI. You can add GraphRAG (4-B) later.

2. Step 0 — Wizard entry (recommended in v2.1)

The easiest path is the `thiscode init` wizard — it auto-detects vault / tools / resources and recommends 8 phases.

```bash
bash ~/.claude/plugins/thiscode/scripts/claude-discode-init.sh
```

What the wizard asks:

- Which Tier's search tool should I install?
- Install GraphRAG? (recommended for 500+ notes — optional anytime)
- Mode R preflight? (recommended for 2000+ notes, read-only)

For step-by-step manual installation, see steps 1~5 below (for users who don't go through the wizard).

3. Step 0 — Environment check (2 min)

First check what is already installed. Open a terminal (Mac = Spotlight `cmd+space` → search “Terminal” / WSL = the Ubuntu app / Linux = Ctrl+Alt+T) and copy + paste + Enter, one line at a time.

3.1. 0-1. Check Node.js

```
node --version
```

✓ **Success looks like** — a number such as `v18.17.0` is fine

❌ **If it fails** — if you see “command not found”, install the LTS version (v18 or v20) from https://nodejs.org and restart your terminal

3.2. 0-2. Check jq

```
jq --version
```

✓ **Success looks like** — output like `jq-1.6`

❌ **If it fails** — Mac: `brew install jq` / Ubuntu / WSL: `sudo apt install jq`

3.3. 0-3. Check git

```
git --version
```

✓ **Success looks like** — `git version 2.x.x`

❌ **If it fails** — Mac: `xcode-select --install` / Ubuntu / WSL: `sudo apt install git`

4. Step 1 — Plugin install (2 min)

```
mkdir -p ~/.claude/plugins
git clone https://github.com/treylom/ThisCode ~/.claude/plugins/thiscode
```

✓ **Success looks like**

```
Cloning into '/Users/.../thiscode'...
remote: Enumerating objects: ...
Receiving objects: 100% (...), done.
```

❌ **If it fails**

- "Permission denied" → check write permission for `mkdir ~/.claude/plugins`
- "already exists" → already installed. Update with `cd ~/.claude/plugins/thiscode && git pull`

5. Step 2 — Install the separate local vault-search MCP (optional)

This installer adds a local embedding tool. Configure km's Tier 3 Obsidian MCP separately through `/km:setup`; this installer does not replace it.

```
bash ~/.claude/plugins/thiscode/scripts/install-vault-search.sh --apply
claude mcp list | grep vault-search
```

✓ **Success looks like** — a single `vault-search` line in the output

❌ **If it fails**

- `claude: command not found` → Claude Code is not installed. https://claude.com/code
- npm install fails → try `nvm use 18` or `nvm install 18`

Important — Restart Claude Code once after install (`exit` then relaunch).

6. Step 3 — Do you use Obsidian? 🤔

Yes → 3-A (Install Obsidian CLI, 3 min)

No → 3-B (Skip, go straight to Step 4)

6.1. 3-A. Install Obsidian CLI (Obsidian users only)

```
bash ~/.claude/plugins/thiscode/scripts/install-obsidian-cli.sh
which obsidian-cli
```

✓ **Success looks like** — a path such as `/usr/local/bin/obsidian-cli`

❌ **If it fails** — add `sudo`, or see the manual-install section in the README

6.2. 3-B. Skip — it still works without Obsidian ✅

- Without Obsidian, check availability of both the CLI and Obsidian MCP separately.
- km skips unavailable stages and uses configured paths such as a GraphRAG server or text search. No fixed percentage of functionality is guaranteed.
- Move on directly to Step 4

7. Step 4 — Going all the way to GraphRAG? 🚀

Pick one of two options:

Choice	Who?	Time
4-A	Skip for now and start with available search	0 min
4-B	Want local Python + direct debugging	About 25 min

7.1. 4-A. Skip for now ✅

→ Jump straight to Step 5

7.2. 4-B. Local Python install

```
python3 --version
bash ~/.claude/plugins/thiscode/scripts/install-graphrag.sh --apply
curl localhost:8400/health
```

Install time 5~10 min + initial indexing 15 min = about 25 min total.

✓ **Success looks like** — `{"status":"ok"}`

8. Step 5 — Verify everything's OK 🎉

```
bash ~/.claude/plugins/thiscode/scripts/healthcheck.sh
```

✓ Local-tool example — unconfigured optional tools show NOT YET

```
thiscode healthcheck v2.3 — Phase progress
─────────────────────────────────
✓ Phase 0 superpowers (plugin)             : OK
✓ Phase 1 ripgrep (local text)             : OK
○ Phase 2 obsidian-cli (local tool)        : NOT YET
○ Phase 3 vault-search MCP (local embedding): NOT YET
○ Phase 4 GraphRAG (local server)          : NOT YET
○ Phase 5 Dense embedding (4-channel)      : NOT YET
─────────────────────────────────
Summary: 2 OK, 4 NOT YET (all required passed) ✅
```

This checks local tools, not km's Obsidian MCP connection or search results. Unconfigured optional tools mean exit 2; a required failure means exit 1; all checks passing means exit 0. Check km search separately with `/km:search`.

❌ If it fails

```
cat ~/.thiscode-setup.log
```

Copy this file's contents into a GitHub Issue: https://github.com/treylom/ThisCode/issues/new?template=setup-failure.yml

9. Try it out

Inside Claude Code:

```
/thiscode:help
```

For vault search, install the km plugin first:

```
claude plugin marketplace add treylom/tofukyung-plugins
claude plugin install km@tofukyung-plugins
/km:search "hello first search"
```

Congratulations! 🎉

10. Frequently Asked Questions

10.1. Q1. Can I stop in the middle of setup?

Yes. After installing and configuring km, start with an available search path. Check actual results with `/km:search` and add optional tools later.

10.2. Q2. macOS / Linux / Windows / WSL — all supported?

macOS / Linux / WSL are verified. Windows native is on the roadmap (WSL recommended for now).

10.3. Q3. I'm a student — what about cost?

- ripgrep and the separate vault-search MCP embedding tool run locally. An MCP connection does not imply a Claude Code subscription benefit or waive API charges.
- Check the applicable terms for Obsidian and your host application.
- GraphRAG API costs depend on the configured provider, model, and vault size.

10.4. Q4. I already use just obsidian-cli — what's the difference?

See the 5-axis benchmark in the README. An earlier ThisCode guide note described a GraphRAG recall uplift over the then-Obsidian CLI baseline, but the archived 2026-05-13 result skipped Tier 1 and Tier 2 under its legacy engine IDs (vault-search MCP used 2, Obsidian CLI used 3), so it does not substantiate a percentage. The note is historical and is not a current km plugin runtime measurement.

- Current trade-off: Tier 2 Obsidian CLI is a lightweight local option, while Tier 1 GraphRAG adds semantic/graph retrieval with more setup and API cost.
- Compare the two on your own fixture; do not reuse the historical percentage.
- But 25-min setup + LLM cost

10.5. Q5. Where do I leave feedback?

GitHub Discussions Feedback category: https://github.com/treylom/ThisCode/discussions/categories/feedback

A 5-question schema, 2 minutes to answer → it feeds into the v1.1 graduate decision.

Need more help?

- GitHub Issues: https://github.com/treylom/ThisCode/issues
- Community: GitHub Discussions
- Docs: SETUP.md (for developers) / AGENTS.md (Custom Hybrid v1.0 spec) / BENCHMARK.md (interpreting the 5 axes)